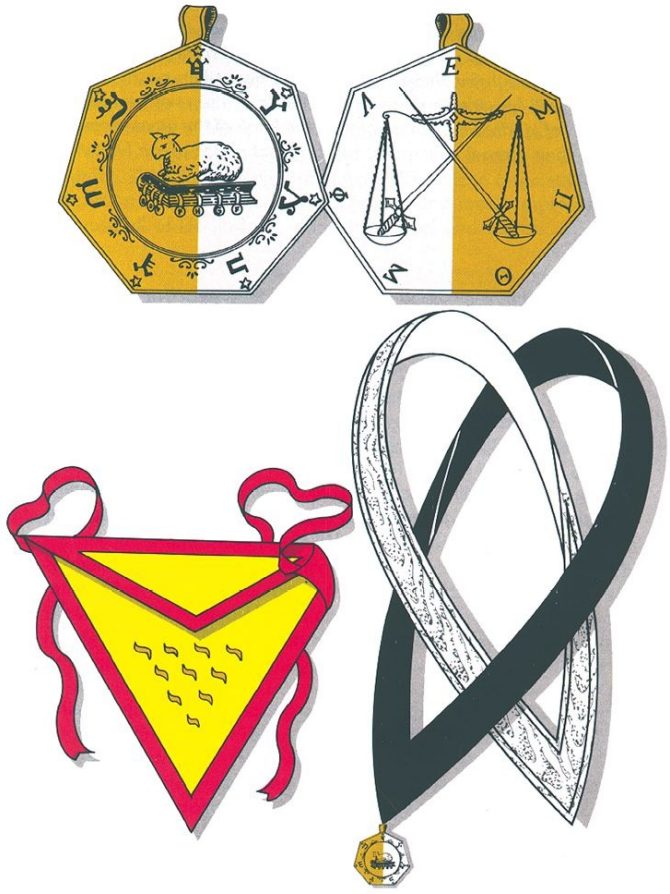
The 17th Degree – Knight of the East and West



The apron is of yellow silk, lined and edged with crimson; the colors are emblematic of the dawn. Its triangular shape is symbolic of the Deity in His first three emanations. In the center is a gold Tetractys formed of 10 Hebrew Yods. They represent the ten Sephiroth (or manifestations of Deity) on the Tree of Life in the Kabbalah.

The order is a broad, white watered ribbon, worn from the right to left. It is crossed by a black one of equal width, worn from left to right. The jewel is suspended from the latter. The two colors are symbolic of the two principles of good and evil as explained in the dualist doctrines of Zoroaster and Manes.

The jewel is a heptagonal (seven–sided) medal, half gold and half silver or mother of pearl. These two colors are emblems of the sun and moon, themselves symbols of the Egyptian deities Osiris and Isis, who represent the generative and

productive powers of nature, illustrated in Masonic symbolism by the columns Jachin and Boaz as the active and passive forces manifested in nature (*Morals and Dogma*, p. 202). On one side are engraved, at the angles, the same letters as are on the capitals of the columns in the ceremony and possessing the same meaning, that of the last seven of the Sephiroth of the Kabbalah. A star is over each. In the center, on the same side, is a lamb, lying on a book with seven seals, on which seals are, respectively, the same letters, though shown in this representation as the Roman equivalents. On the reverse side are two crossed swords, points upward; their hilts rest on an even balance. In the corners are the initials in Greek of the names of the Seven Churches (Revelation 2 and 3).

DUTIES

To work, to reflect and to pray. To hope, to trust and to believe. To teach the truths that are hidden in allegories and concealed by the symbols of Freemasonry.

LESSON

An army of martyrs have offered up their lives to prove their faith or benefit mankind.

FOR REFLECTION

Can Masonry teach religion without being a religion?
What is the meaning of the vacant chair in the ceremony?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

The East, the West, John the Baptist, the colors of the rainbow, the candidate, the number seven, the vacant chair.

While many of the Scottish Rite ceremonies are infused with quotes and paraphrases from Scripture, here the events in the drama and many of the words in the ritual are directly taken from the Revelation of God through Jesus Christ to St. John the Evangelist. This is the last book of the New Testament and is also called the Apocalypse to St. John, from the Greek apocalypsis meaning revelation. Generally, apocalypses are secret books intended for the initiated.

The fundamental idea in the Apocalypse is that the East will one day dominate the whole of the world again and the final victory will be Israel's. The document predicts an awaiting catastrophe for the world, the Second Coming of Christ and the glorious future that awaits mankind after the last decisive conflict, the triumph of good over evil.

CEREMONY

Bodies of this degree are called Preceptories and consist of only twenty–four members, a reference to the twenty–four elders mentioned in Revelation 4:4. The Council Chamber is heptagon–shaped (seven sided), hung with crimson sprinkled with gold stars. Each corner contains a square column of a different color; they are red, orange, yellow, green, blue, indigo and violet. These colors and their order suggest a rainbow like that surrounding the head of the angel in Revelation 10:1 or the colors which comprise white light, manifesting the various hues when passed through a prism and divided into the colors of the spectrum. Since light is a symbol of knowledge, the seven colors represent the seven liberal arts and sciences illustrated in the Fellowcraft Degree– grammar, rhetoric, logic, arithmetic, geometry, music and astronomy. The rainbow on the cover illustration carries exactly this same meaning. Their presence here is a hint of that which is taught in the higher degrees; they will be described further in the 30th Degree. On each column is a Hebrew or Samaritan letter, the initials of the names of the last seven *sephiroth* (or emanations from Deity) spoken of in the Kabbalah. On each column are the words: Union, Honor, Duty, Loyalty, Courage, Discretion, and Silence; all knightly virtues.

In the East, seven steps ascend to a platform on which is the altar and a vacant chair. On the altar is a book sealed with seven seals (Revelation 5:1) .

The tracing board contains the initials and words which are on the seven columns, a man with white hair and beard, dressed in a white robe, and holding seven stars (Revelation 1:14–16). There are also seven candlesticks and over each one is a Greek letter, each represents one of the seven churches (Revelation 2 & 3) in existence about 90 A.D. when the Book was written.

The Master represents John the Baptist. It is believed by many that John the Baptist was a member of the Essenes, a small group of Jewish ascetics living near the Dead Sea. They practiced celibacy and thus maintained their group by admitting converts who were required to pass through a series of solemn initiations. Mackey says that upon admission to the highest grade, “the candidate was bound by a solemn oath to love God, to be just to all men, to practice charity, maintain truth, and to conceal the secrets of the society and the mysteries connected with the Tetragrammaton and the other names of God” (Vol. 1, p. 339).

Noted Masonic scholars have attempted to trace the beginnings of Masonry to the Essenes, relying on the similarity of the above traits in the two groups. The candidate symbolically becomes an Essene in the first section of the degree where he is prepared for the great mysteries of the Book with the Seven Seals.

The introductory drama represents the audience chamber of King Herod II. The King expresses an interest in the doctrines of the Essenes, and he summons John to teach him. But John calls the King to repentance for his sins. This drama is not historical, but is only to prepare the candidates for the great lessons of the degree. Angered at John, Herod has him thrown into prison when the drama of John’s execution is recited.

At the beginning of the reception white curtains conceal the platform, the altar, the hangings and the twenty–four chairs in the Chamber of Council. The candidate is received as a weary traveler who has crossed the desert and now wanders on the shore of the Dead Sea in darkness seeking light. The candidate is himself a symbol of the human soul, weary of the unprofitable speculation and empty logic of existing philosophies. The Dead Sea symbolizes the philosophies of Egypt and Greece which gave men little hope of eternal life.

Many questions concerning the candidate’s performance of his prior Masonic obligations are asked. As he is conducted around the room, selected verses from Revelation are recited. The message is one of repentance. The candidate is admonished to be zealous and in so doing help to achieve immortality with God (Revelation 2:26; 3:5, 12, 21).

Scholars believe purification by water and fire was an integral part of the Essenes' initiation ceremonies. This degree symbolically enacts this ancient custom of baptizing the candidate with the spirit (water) and with fire; this is a reference, from Matthew 3:10–11, to the words spoken by John the Baptist to those whom he baptized, "One cometh hereafter who shall baptize you with the Holy Spirit and with fire ... His axe is prepared for the trees; and every tree that beareth not good fruit will be cut down, and cast into the fire." Once purified, the candidate becomes God's soldier to war against fanaticism, intolerance, bigotry and all the evils which have made a hell of earth, which was created a paradise. These evils, which cause the suffering of man, strengthen the human soul and offer an incentive for the noblest virtues. The last trial the candidate undergoes symbolically illustrates the fidelity and courage required of a Knight of the East and West who is always ready to lay his life upon the altar of God, of friendship, of his country or of the human race.

The markedly Christian symbolism present in this degree may possibly cause some confusion or misunderstanding. Pike relied on the teachings of many faiths in his reworking of the Scottish Rite degrees and in this respect Christianity was not slighted. The magnificent symbolic allegory in the Apocalypse was too great a temptation for the mystical tendencies of such as Albert Pike and we see much of the literary beauty of that Book presented here.

It is important to stress, however, that the symbolism is borrowed to teach different lessons from those taught in the Book of Revelation itself. These lessons are not intended to replace those of any faith but are rather simple opportunities for further instruction on the importance of moral rectitude. For example, the Book of Seven Seals used in the ceremony of the degree of Knight of the East and West is but a symbol to encourage the candidates to study what the Book of Revelation teaches. Only Christ is worthy to open that Book, and in the ritual the Book of Seven Seal remains closed throughout. Such symbols are to be seen as analogies and not equivalencies. Masonry does not teach the falseness of any faith—all are equally respected and honored by the Fraternity

each candidate is expected to reserve unto himself the tenets and teachings of his faith, and, most importantly, to live them.

The vivid imagery from the Book of Revelation is again included in the ritual in an abbreviated form. The opening of the seals ushers in the most dreadful disasters: four horsemen set off, one after the other, creating war, strife, dissension, famine and plague. The opening of the fifth seal brings into sight the souls of the dead martyrs crying out for vengeance. The opening of the sixth seal brings a great earthquake. The opening of the seventh seal brings silence followed by the sounding of trumpets which announce the last battle at the end of time. The world is ravaged by hail and fire, a volcanic eruption, a falling star, an eclipse, locusts and four demons slaying a third of mankind. The seventh and last trumpet announces that God and his Messiah have made the earth the Kingdom of God and He shall reign forever.

While conveying the events described in the Revelation to St. John, the ritual contributes a Masonic interpretation. It is not offered as a substitution to a religious interpretation, but it is seen within the context of the great lessons of our Fraternity. Thus, the spirits of evil on earth are the locusts of ignorance, fanaticism and superstition. The four demons are bigotry, intolerance, ambition and selfishness. Thought, speech and conscience struggle to be free. Truth, which is the Kingdom of God, will remain forever; sorrow and evil will disappear. In time, all men will be judged by God and rewarded accordingly.

LECTURE

As the first of the Philosophical Degrees of the Scottish Rite, the lecture of the 17th Degree in *Morals and Dogma* is devoted to an overview of the doctrines of the ancients which are found in Masonry. It teaches the same philosophical truths taught by the Essenes and preached by John the Baptist. Pike believed they gathered these truths from the doctrines of both the East and the West. The great truths come from the Zend–Avesta of the Persians, the Vedas of the Hindus, the writings of Plato and Pythagoras, from the ancient countries of Phoenicia, Syria, Greece and Egypt and from the Holy Books of the Jews. Masonry gleaned the

truth from the error in these ancient doctrines and continues to pass it on. They are very simple and sublime lessons: God is one, immutable, unchangeable, infinitely just and good; light will finally overcome darkness, good conquer evil, and truth be victor over error.

The following selections from *Morals and Dogma* were chosen for their simplicity from a very complex presentation of the religious philosophies of the ancients of the East and West. Pike understood the complexity inherent in a comparative study of ancient religious philosophies, for he begins this lecture:

This is the first of the Philosophical Degrees of the Ancient and Accepted Scottish Rite; and the beginning of a course of instruction which will fully unveil to you the heart and inner mysteries of Masonry. Do not despair because you have often seemed on the point of attaining the inmost light, and have as often been disappointed. In all time, truth has been hidden under symbols, and often under a succession of allegories: where veil after veil had to be penetrated before the true Light was reached, and the essential truth stood revealed. The Human Light is but an imperfect reflection of a ray of the Infinite and Divine (p. 246).

It is only on the last page of the lengthy and detailed lecture that we learn why it is important to study those old, strange, mysterious creeds and faiths, shrouded in the mists of antiquity (p. 247)

... the Truth separated from Error, Masonry has garnered up in her heart of hearts, and through the fires of persecution, and the storms of calamity, has brought them and delivered them unto us. ... Those speculations and fancies [the Error] it is useful to study; that knowing in what worthless and unfruitful investigations the mind may engage, you may the more value and appreciate the plain, simple, sublime, universally–acknowledged truths, which have in all ages been the Light by which Masons have been guided on their way; the Wisdom and Strength that like imperishable columns have sustained and will continue to sustain its glorious and magnificent Temple (p. 275).

The great truths which Masonry has maintained were shared in common among many of the ancient religious philosophies; of course, the name given to a concept was different from one creed to another. Pike briefly summarizes these great truths; these summaries are reproduced here:

And all these creeds, while admitting these different manifestations of the Supreme Being, held that His identity was immutable and permanent (pp. 271–272).

...one grand idea ever emerged and stood prominent and unchangeable over the weltering chaos of confusion. God is great, and good, and wise. Evil and pain and sorrow are temporary, and for wise and beneficent purposes. They must be consistent with God's goodness, purity, and infinite perfection; and there must be a mode of explaining them; .... Ultimately, Good will prevail, and Evil be overthrown. God alone can do this, and He will do it, by an Emanation from Himself, assuming the Human form and redeeming the world (p. 274).